

4-7 JUNE 1942
The USA defeats Japan's navy at the Battle of Midway in the Pacific Ocean, halting the Japanese advance.

Soviet medal for the Battle of Stalingrad



2 FEBRUARY 1943
Soviet troops are victorious at Stalingrad and begin to march on Germany.



German V1 flying bomb, 1944

25 AUGUST 1944
Paris is liberated by the Allies from German occupation.

7 MARCH 1945
Allied troops cross the river Rhine and enter Germany.



Model of "fat man" atomic bomb, dropped on Nagasaki

6-9 AUGUST 1945
USA drops atomic bombs on the Japanese cities of Hiroshima and Nagasaki.

1945



Japanese Aichi D3A bomber plane

19 AUGUST 1942
Germany launches an attempt to take over the Soviet city of Stalingrad.

13 MAY 1943
The Axis armies in North Africa surrender.

25 JULY 1943
Italian dictator Mussolini is overthrown. A month later, the Allies invade mainland Italy, leading to Italy's surrender.

6 JUNE 1944
D-Day: Allied forces land in Normandy, France, and begin to advance inland.



Badge worn by Jews in Latvia

27 JANUARY 1945
Soviet army liberates the Auschwitz death camp in Poland.

7 MAY 1945
Following Hitler's suicide a week earlier, Germany surrenders.

15 AUGUST 1945
Japan announces its intention to surrender. On 2 September they sign the Instrument of Surrender, and World War II is officially over.



GERMAN ARMY BADGE
The Nazis used the swastika cross as their symbol.

HITLER AND THE NAZIS

Adolf Hitler was the leader of the Nazi (National Socialist) party. Nazis believed that Germans were naturally superior to what they called "inferior races". Hitler especially hated Jewish people, and blamed them for all of Germany's economic and political problems.

CASUALTIES OF WAR

Both sides suffered terrible losses during the war. Poland lost 20 per cent of its population, and whole cities across Europe were left in ruins. The Nazis and their sympathizers executed six million Jewish people. This brutal, systematic murder is now known as the Holocaust. In Japan two nuclear bombs, dropped by the USA, caused mass destruction. In the city of Hiroshima, 65,000 people were killed, and in Nagasaki 40,000 lost their lives.



HOLOCAUST MEMORIAL IN BERLIN, GERMANY



PEACE MEMORIAL IN HIROSHIMA, JAPAN

DURING THE BLITZ OF 1940-41, MORE THAN A MILLION HOMES IN LONDON WERE DESTROYED

APPROXIMATE TOTAL CASUALTIES PER COUNTRY

SOVIET UNION	24 MILLION
CHINA	20 MILLION
GERMANY	6.6-8.8 MILLION
POLAND	5.6 MILLION
JAPAN	2.6-3.1 MILLION
YUGOSLAVIA	1 MILLION
ROMANIA	833,000
HUNGARY	580,000
FRANCE	567,600
PHILIPPINES	500,000-1 MILLION
ITALY	457,000
UNITED KINGDOM	450,700
UNITED STATES OF AMERICA	418,500
NETHERLANDS	301,000
GREECE	300,000-800,000
FINLAND	97,000
BELGIUM	86,100
CANADA	45,400
AUSTRALIA	40,500
BULGARIA	25,000
NORWAY	9,500

LAND POWER

Advances in technology meant that armoured vehicles and tanks played a much bigger part in World War II than in previous conflicts. Panzer tanks, supported by air bombers, were the main power behind the Germans' swift and brutal takeover of most of Western Europe in the first months of the war.



UNIVERSAL CARRIER UK



SHERMAN FIREFLY UK/USA



M2 HALF-TRACK CAR USA



BMW R12 MOTORCYCLE Germany



WHITE SCOUT CAR USA



STURMGESCHÜTZ III Germany



CHURCHILL TANK UK



JAGDPANZER 38(T) HETZER Germany



PANZERKAMPFWAGEN II Germany



PANZERKAMPFWAGEN III Germany

PANZERKAMPFWAGEN "TIGER" II Germany



SEA POWER

Naval battles took place in both the Atlantic and Pacific oceans. In the North Atlantic, German U-boats (submarines) stalked and attacked the Allies' essential supply ships. In the Pacific, the USA took on the Japanese in a series of massive naval battles.



HMS AVON VALE Escort destroyer, UK



HMS AGINCOURT Battle class destroyer, UK



U-BOAT (SUBMARINE) Germany



USS HORNET Aircraft carrier, USA



HMS HOOD Battlecruiser, UK



YAHAGI Cruiser, Japan



I-400-CLASS SUBMARINE Japan



PRINZ EUGEN Heavy cruiser, Germany